Orange County Register, The (Santa Ana, CA) - October 4, 2026 - page 9
October 4, 2026 | Orange County Register, The (Santa Ana, CA) | Santa Ana, California | Page 9

POLITICS

Becerra backers accuse Hilton campaign of hiding payments to influencers

By Ben Paviour and Lia Russell
THE SACRAMENTO BEE

SACRAMENTO — Two vocal supporters of Democratic gubernatorial hopeful Xavier Becerra filed a formal campaign finance complaint against his rival, Steve Hilton, this week over the Republican campaign's use of paid online promoters.

The Becerra supporters, Beatrice Gomberg and Kaitlyn Hennessy, claim Hilton is engaging in a "misinformation campaign" involving social media accounts, conservative media figures and alleged whistleblowers who have criticized Becerra's oversight of child migrants as former U.S. secretary of health and human services under President Joe Biden.

In some cases, Gomberg and Hennessy point to campaign finance records to argue that two influencers — self-described independent journalists — were paid more than $70,000 by the campaign.

In others, they ask the California Fair Political Practices Commission to investigate what they argue were suspicious signs that people or marketing firms had been paid without proper disclosures.

"It is impossible to tell how many different third party influencers have been paid by the committee to create this pro-Hilton content, but we provide below a list we believe to capture at least some of those influencers," said Hennessy and Gomberg in their complaint, filed Tuesday. "Based on our research, none of the posts these creators have published include a disclaimer."

The two women are themselves influencers who previously accused former gubernatorial hopeful Tom Steyer and, earlier this week, Los Angeles mayoral hopeful Nithya Raman of similar infractions. The Fair Political Practices Commission cleared Steyer of wrongdoing earlier this month.

The Hilton complaint was filed against the campaign rather than the online supporters themselves.

Newsom recently signed a new law that would also subject influencers to a $5,000-per-post penalty for failing to disclose campaign payments, but it does not go into effect until January.

Hilton's spokesperson, Hector Barajas, said influencers had been instructed to add disclaimers to campaign posts after inquiries by The Sacramento Bee.

In a statement, Hilton suggested the complaint originated from Becerra's campaign — something Gomberg and Hennessy deny — and was an attempt to distract from the Democrat's oversight of the influx of child migrants beginning in 2021.

"It is truly despicable that instead of apologizing for his role in sending thousands of Latino children into the clutches of child sex and labor traffickers, or withdrawing from public life in shame and disgrace, as frankly he should have done years ago, this appalling man is lashing out at the investigative journalists who for years have been putting their lives at risk to expose the horror of cartel operations enabled by Biden's open border policy and Becerra's migrant child abuse camps," Hilton said.

Becerra

Hilton

Two of the most prominent pro-Hilton influencers named in the complaint, Anthony Rubin and Jorge Ventura, both produce content focused on Becerra's tenure as HHS secretary.

A 2023 Pulitzer-winning New York Times investigation found that thousands of children were trafficked into unsafe jobs under Becerra's watch.

Becerra, who was repeatedly attacked by primary rivals over his handling of the issue, called those criticisms "Trump lies," saying it was employers, not his agency, that mistreated the children.

Rubin and Ventura interviewed two youth who said they were victims of trafficking, a former caseworker and a former site supervisor of a San Diego detention center.

They produced videos and spoke at a news conference Hilton hosted in July that aimed to provide more detail on alleged workplace and sexual abuses that critics claim occurred under Becerra's watch.

Gomberg and Hennessy asked the FPPC to investigate whether the two youth who were allegedly trafficked had been paid for their testimony, "given the fact that the only record of their claims are by people paid by the Steve Hilton campaign."

Barajas said the youth featured were not compensated for their interviews.

Campaign finance filings released earlier this week show Hilton's campaign paid Rubin's Muckraker Media $60,383.55 for unspecified campaign consultant work and travel expenses. Ventura received $12,000 for unspecified campaign consultant work.

"Muckraker and (Ventura) are independent investigators who covered this issue, helped find these immigrants under these circumstances, and conducted the interviews," Barajas said in an email. "They were paid to look for (the whistleblowers) and film (them)."

Hilton, Rubin and Ventura did not disclose the payments at the Aug. 5 news conference or in social media posts related to the event. In Rubin's case, that amounted to a single video of him speaking at the event, while Ventura posted nearly two dozen times praising Hilton or attacking Becerra.

When The Fresno Bee asked Hilton if he'd paid Rubin for the footage featured at that event, Hilton said he had not.

In response to questions from The Sacramento Bee, Barajas said Hilton meant that the campaign hadn't paid Rubin for the substance of his reporting on the topic, which predates Hilton's campaign.

Rubin and Ventura declined to answer specific questions about their work for the Hilton campaign.

Gomberg and Hennessy's complaint also names a third man, a former detention center supervisor named Tarek Kadourah who told Ventura that he witnessed migrant children being handed off to sponsors with little vetting and that his internal complaints were ignored.

The Hilton campaign reimbursed Kadourah $406 for travel and lodging and listed him as a "member of the staff" in campaign filings. Gomberg and Hennessy argue that language suggested Kadourah was paid as part of the campaign, and should have disclosed that connections on his social media posts on the campaign.

Both Kadourah and Barajas said that Kadourah was in fact not employed by the campaign.

In an interview, Kadourah said he identifies as an independent politically and is ineligible to vote in the governor's race because he lives in Texas, although he's described himself as a Hilton supporter on Instagram.

Kadourah said he'd accepted Hilton's campaign invitation to do the interview out of disgust with Becerra's handling of the migrant crisis. He said that he volunteers to rescue trafficked children with a nonprofit, often posting about it on an Instagram page that is peppered with heavily-armed selfies from far-flung locales.

Hennessy and Gomberg's complaint also urges regulators to investigate Hilton campaign payments to the firms Cliplabs and Affiliate Net, arguing both firms may have hired people to boost Hilton online. California law requires sub-vendors — in this case, those social media users — to be listed in campaign finance reports.

Barajas said the two firms were paid for "video clipping and social media distribution services."

The Becerra supporters also identified a handful of pro-Hilton social media accounts which disclosed payments from the Republican in their page information but not on individual posts.

In a joint interview, Hennessy and Gomberg argued that disclosures changed how social media users viewed self-described journalists like Rubin and Ventura.

"They're more valuable if people don't think they're paid to post on behalf of a campaign," Hennessy said. "When people see this, they don't understand that the person posting has a financial incentive."

Barajas said they're missing the point.

"Becerra would rather talk about who held the camera than what is on the tape," he said.

LAWS

From Page 1

more training opportunities for people to recognize opioid overdoses and administer naloxone to considering forced marriage as grounds for seeking a domestic violence restraining order. There's legislation requiring high school coaches to complete mental health training to better help their players, and another creating a first-in-the-nation state seal to identify non-ultraprocessed foods.

Of the bills sent to Newsom in 2026, he signed 1,040, meaning he vetoed just 10.3% of them, according to veteran Sacramento lobbyist Chris Micheli's tally.

During his eight years in office, Newsom vetoed 13.5% of the bills that landed on his desk, according to Micheli. That's fairly on par with former Gov. Jerry Brown, also a Democrat, Micheli's research found, but a bit fewer than Republican Gov. Arnold Schwarzenegger, who clocked in with a 26.5% veto rate.

But back to Newsom, and the final slate of bills before him in his last year as California's governor. Here's a brief look at a handful of the ones he signed ahead of last Wednesday's deadline.

Getting up to speed on math: Younger students struggling with math will be identified earlier and connected to support faster because of a new law that requires annual math tests to help educators identify these students before academic gaps among classmates grow further.

SB 1067 requires that schools begin testing their kindergartners', first graders' and second graders' math skills annually, starting with the 2028-29 school year. Students identified as needing extra math help through these tests will receive "evidence-based interventions" to help them get back on track, according to bill author Sen. Akilah Weber Pierson, D-San Diego.

The California Department of Education must post online by July 31 the criteria and guidance for selecting appropriate math tests for students, and by the end of January 2028 it will publish a list of approved tests for local education agencies to select from.

Labeling healthy food: California is the first state to pass a law creating an official state seal to identify non-ultraprocessed foods.

AB 2244, authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, paves the way for manufacturers to voluntarily undergo evaluation that their products meet the state's definition for non-ultraprocessed foods. Those who meet the standards may affix a "Non-Ultraprocessed Certified" state seal on the front of their food packaging to help shoppers easily identify which food products are healthier. The concept is modeled after the "USDA Organic" labeling program.

The California Department of Public Health will accredit the entities approved by the state to certify the food products by June 1, 2029.

Large grocery stores will also have to prominently display items with the "Non-Ultraprocessed Certified" seal to make it easier for shoppers to find the products.

Ultraprocessed foods are high in saturated fat, added sugar or sodium and contain additives such as flavorings, colorings, emulsifiers or thickening agents. They're often filled with harmful additives to enhance the taste, texture, appearance or shelf life of a product and can, as in the case of soda, be addictive.

Research has linked these foods to cancer, cardiovascular disease, Type 2 diabetes, metabolic disorders, obesity and other health concerns.

Keeping access to autism behavioral health treatments: Starting Jan. 1, Californians with autism who have been prescribed a behavioral healthcare treatment plan by a provider will no longer lose access to that treatment simply because they miss an appointment.

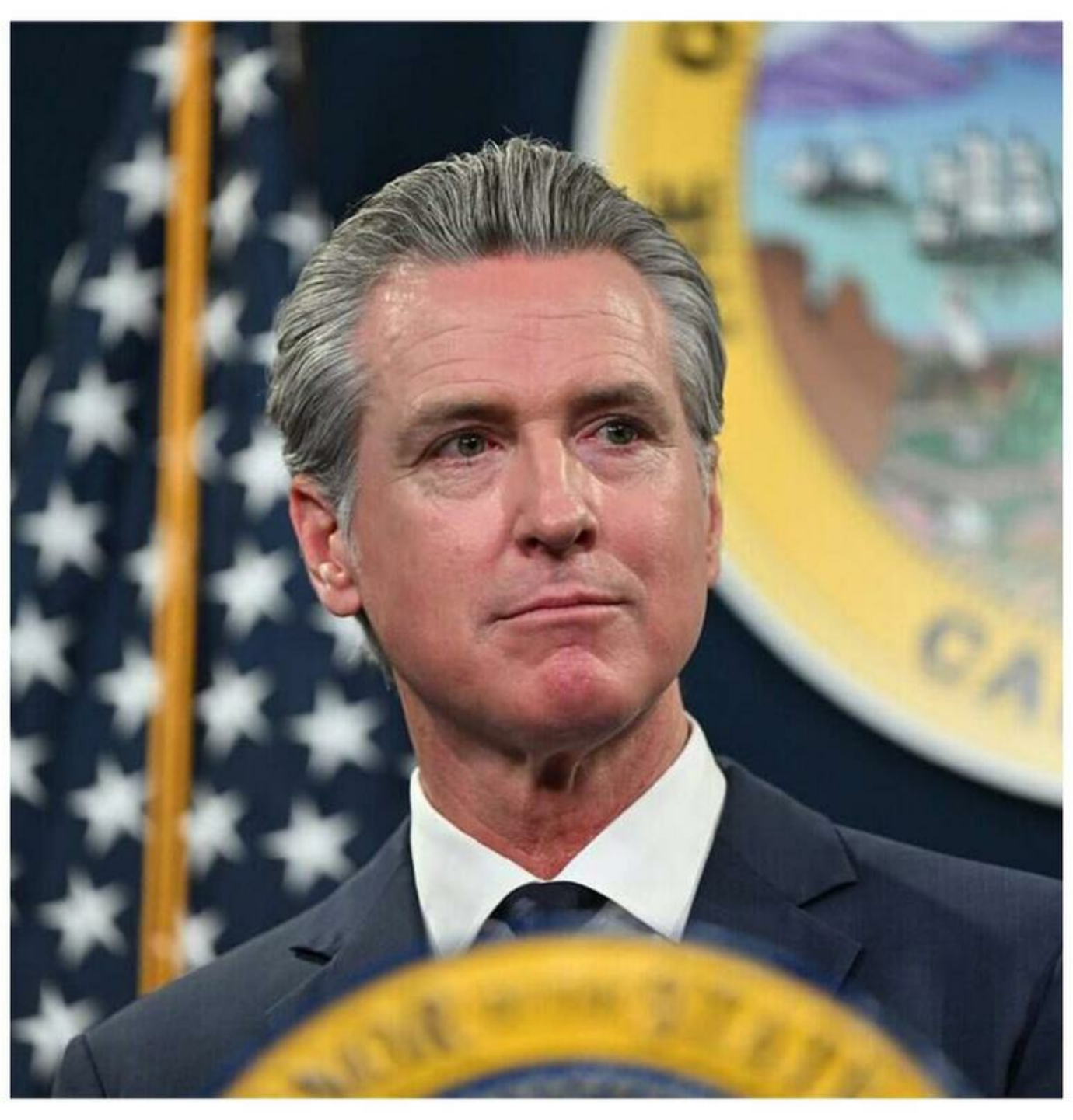
Families now could lose out on their already-approved treatment if they miss an appointment, even if it's due to unavoidable circumstances.

But the new law, from Assemblymember Tri Ta, R-Westminster, prohibits health plans and insurers from placing restrictions on patients and their families from using those approved treatment hours, so long as accessing treatment is reasonably consistent with the treatment plan and guidelines.

The law also allows healthcare plans to conduct utilization reviews of the services and treatment provided, when appropriate.

Identifying 'forever chemicals': Gabriel was not the only Los Angeles County lawmaker to have a food-related bill signed by Newsom this legislative session.

Assemblymember Nick Schultz, D-Burbank, authored AB 1603, which requires the California Department of Pesticide Regulation to disclose online if a pesticide contains perfluoroalkyl and polyfluoroalkyl substances.


Gov. Gavin Newsom signed 1,160 bills sent to his desk by the California Legislature in 2026 and vetoed 10.3% of the legislation passed at the state Capitol, according to a veteran Sacramento lobbyist. Newsom, pictured during a budget presentation on May 14 at the Capitol Swing Space building in Sacramento, is in his last year in office due to term limits. **HECTOR AMEZCUA — THE SACRAMENTO BEE/TNS**

Otherwise known as PFAS, these are considered toxic "forever chemicals" because they take decades, if not hundreds of years or more, to break down. That slow process results in a buildup of the substances in the environment and inside our bodies.

PFAS exposure can increase cholesterol levels or the risk of obesity, decrease fertility and impact development, including causing low birth weight, bone variations or behavioral changes, and have been linked to other health issues, according to environmental experts and advocates.

Schultz initially proposed banning PFAS pesticides from being used on crops grown in California over time. But the bill was amended during the legislative approval process before reaching Newsom's desk.

Now, it only requires the Department of Pesticide Regulation to indicate PFAS-containing pesticides in a database on its website by Jan. 1, 2028, or by the time its pesticide use reporting database includes 2026 data, whichever comes first. The department must also publish a list of all registered pesticides with PFAS ingredients by Jan. 1, 2028, and provide this list to each county in the state.

Coaching mental health: Coaches already receive training to help their players if they are injured physically. Now, they will also have to undergo behavioral and mental health training every two years to help them recognize and respond to students who may be struggling mentally.

Newsom actually signed multiple bills that addressed mental health training for coaches: AB 1665 from Assemblymember Blanca Pacheco, D-Downey, and AB 1626 from Gabriel, the Encino Democrat.

There is also AB 1985 from Assemblymember Jacqui Irwin, D-Thousand Oaks, which requires mental health training for Cal State and community college coaches and requests it of UC coaches.

The idea is for coaches to be able to better spot signs of anxiety, depression, eating disorders, substance abuse and suicidal ideation and then connect students to support and resources, the bill sponsors said.

Gabriel's bill also saw support from Golden State Warriors basketball player Stephen Curry, who said these policies "help create a strong foundation for coaching practices that can make a lasting impact in an athlete's life."

Providing security for faith-based communities: The Safe Worship Zone Act, authored by Assemblymember Rebecca Bauer-Kahan, a Democrat from the Bay Area, aims to protect congregants at a synagogue, church, mosque, temple or other religious place of worship from being harassed by protesters.

AB 2664 makes it illegal, within 100 feet of an entrance or exit of a house of worship, for a protester to get within 8 feet of another person entering or leaving the building without their consent to hand out literature, display a sign, engage in oral protest, obstruct their movement or harass or intimidate them.

A first-time offender could be fined up to $1,000, face up to six months of jail time or both. Each subsequent violation could result in a fine of up to $5,000, a jail sentence of up to one year or both.

"For too long, too many people have been asked to accept fear as part of practicing their faith. … AB 2664 says we cannot accept that as normal, and it should never become the norm. This bill creates a safe bubble zone around houses of worship so people of all faiths can worship with the dignity, peace, and security they deserve," Bauer-Kahan said.

The bill was introduced partly in response to an incident at Wilshire Boulevard Temple in Los Angeles in December when protesters reportedly blocked people from entering the building and later entered the facility themselves, disrupting an event while shouting antisemitic remarks, destroying property and assaulting a security guard, according to Jewish community leaders.

Protecting those in forced or child marriages: Billed by supporters as landmark legislation, Newsom also approved AB 2534, which recognizes forced marriage as a form of domestic violence, giving grounds for a victim to petition a court for a domestic violence restraining order.

The bill from Assemblymember Ash Kalra, D-San Jose, defines forced marriage as "a spousal relationship in which one or both parties do not or cannot consent and one or both parties are compelled, through force, fraud, coercion, duress, abuse of power, or coercive control, to enter, attempt to enter, or maintain, a marriage, regardless of whether the marriage is legally valid."

Forced marriage is already a crime, the bill analysis noted, but victims can still find themselves in it without protective measures — and at times, the perpetrator acts not alone but with the help of family or community members.

The new law gives courts "clear authority to intervene before someone is forced onto a plane, before their passport is confiscated, before they are pulled out of school, and before they are forced to sign away their childhood," according to the Tahirih Justice Center, a national nonprofit that serves immigrant survivors of gender-based violence.

Newsom also signed legislation from Assemblymember Gail Pellerin, D-Santa Cruz, that bans child marriage in California. The bill does away with the ability for minors to enter into a marriage or domestic partnership with parental consent and sets the minimum age for such relationships at 18.

According to Newsom's office, only 17 states have banned child marriage outright.

Training to recognize opioid overdoses: Those required to undergo CPR training because of their jobs will also now receive online training on how to use naloxone in an attempt to stop opioid overdoses.

Many overdoses occur in public places where CPR-certified people are already present, according to Assemblymember Matt Haney, D-San Francisco. The idea is that by increasing the number of people who can recognize an opioid overdose and know how to administer naloxone, which can help restore breathing to someone suffering an overdose, the response time to give critical aid will be reduced.

The bill received near-unanimous support in the statehouse.

Protecting special needs trusts: Proposition 19, approved by California voters in 2020, gave older adults at least 55 years old, the disabled and wildfire victims the ability to carry low property tax assessments with them when they moved.

But a new law now clarifies that severely disabled people who have inherited homes held in a Special Needs Trust are also protected under Proposition 19.

There was uncertainty with that measure, according to Sen. Kelly Seyarto, R-Murrieta, over whether it included Special Needs Trusts, which are a specific type of trust that allows disabled people to maintain eligibility for public assistance benefits, like Medicaid or Supplemental Security Income, even if they had assets that would make them otherwise ineligible.

"Families caring for a loved one with a severe disability already have a lot to consider when planning for their future," Seyarto said of SB 974, calling it a "common-sense clarification."

"They should not have to worry that doing the responsible thing could result in an unintended tax consequence," he said.

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